Sweet Tooth

By Margi Palatini

This is Stewart. Your typical, average, everyday kid. Except for one thing.

SWEET TOOTH: Iii oo-er ere.

Ahh, yes. There it is all right. The molar in the back. You're probably saying, "A tooth? What's the big deal about a tooth?" And ordinarily you would be correct. . . . But that is no ordinary tooth. Uh-uh. This is Stewart's sweet tooth. One nagging, annoying, demanding . . .

SWEET TOOTH: *(Loudly)* BLAH. BLAH. BLAH. ENOUGH WITH THE YAKKIN'. I NEED A CANDY BAR. NOW-OW!

. . . very loud, sweet tooth.

INTRODUCTION

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SWEET TOOTH: "DOES IT HAVE THAT GOOEY STUFF IN THE MIDDLE? 'CAUSE IT'S GOT TO HAVE THAT GOOEY STUFF IN THE MID-DLE!"

STEWART: *(Cramming a candy bar into his mouth, chewing loudly and gulping)* There. Satisfied?

SWEET TOOTH: AHHHHH . . . SWEET!

Yes, a tooth that wants what it wants, when it wants it . . . and lets everybody know it. Take, for example, two years ago at cousin Charlotte's wedding . . . Stewart was on his best behavior. His shoes were shined. Bowtie straight. Hands were spotless. Grandfather had just lifted his glass to toast the bride and groom when . . .

SWEET TOOTH: I'm fallin' asleep here! Come on. Move it along, Gramps. Cut the cake. Time to cut the cake. I want the end hunk with all that iiiiii-icing.

MOTHER: *(through a gritted smile)* I don't know him.

DAD: *(under his breath)* He doesn't belong to me.

GRANDMOTHER: *(muttering)* Who is that boy?

Stewart wiped the pink rose from his lips.

STUART: It's The Sweet Tooth.

It was not a pretty picture . . . The Tooth was no better behaved in school. Stewart had enough detention slips to wallpaper his room. Why, just two weeks ago in geography class . . .

MRS. FINNEGAN: Who can tell me the capital of North Dakota?"

SWEET TOOTH: *(muffled)* Jelly beans

NARRATOR: said a muffled voice from the back of the room.

MRS. FINNEGAN: Did you say something, Stewart?

SWEET TOOTH: Licorice.

MRS. FINNEGAN: Stewart, I'm afraid I can't hear your answer.

SWEET TOOTH: Lollipops.

MRS. FINNEGAN: You're going to have to speak up, Stewart.

SWEET TOOTH: Hey! I'm dying here for a couple of CHOCOLATE PEANUT BUTIER CUPS, OKAY?!

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Detention slip number 432.

STEWART: *(as he is lead away to the principal's office)*

But, I'm telling you, it's not me, It's The Tooth!

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The movies? You don't really want to go there, do you? . . . Not with Stewart, anyway.

SWEET TOOTH: Would somebody pass the yummy yummys, already?!

CROWD: SHHHHHHHHHHHHH!

STEWART: *(chewing)* Don't look at me . . . It's The Tooth.

And of course there was the unforgettable "Easter Basket Mishap." Now that was really ugly. That Sunday A.M. the family awoke to find jelly beans littering the living room. Marshmallow chicks were missing. The trail of crumpled yellow foil wrappers led to one person, and one person only.

MOTHER/DAD: *(disappointed)* Ooooh, Stewart.

SISTER: *(whimpering and closing her eyes)* I can't look.

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STEWART: *(moaning and rubbing his belly-aching stomach)* Those chocolate bunnies never had a chance . . . It was The Tooth.

SWEET TOOTH: HEY! CAN WE STOP GOING DOWN MEMORY LANE HERE AND OPEN UP THAT BAG OF COOKIES?

STEWART: That's it. I've had enough!

SWEET TOOTH: ENOUGH? I HAVEN'T EVEN HAD ONE.

STEWART: *(shouting)* No more cookies! No more candy. No more cake. No more nothing!

SWEET TOOTH: That's no more ***anything***. And . . . WHO DO YOU THINK YOU'RE KIDDING, KID? Bring on those chocolate chips!"

Stewart sighed. What choice did he have? He was a boy with one big Sweet Tooth. He tore open the bag. He grabbed one, then two-three-four cookies. He opened his mouth.

SWEET TOOTH: *(shouting)* COME TO PAPA!

Stewart stopped.

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SWEET TOOTH: What are you waiting for, kid? Come on. Cookie. Cookie. Cookie. Cookie.

Stewart dropped the cookies. But . . . . not in his mouth.

STEWART: *(determined)* It's over, Tooth. I'm cutting you off. Starting right now. It's cold turkey.

SWEET TOOTH: Cold turkey? Yee-ech! I hate cold turkey . . . unless you add a little cranberry sauce,

STEWART: Didn't you hear me, Tooth? I said it's over. From now on there's nothing for you but a . . . a . . . a . . . (large gulp) Healthy diet.

SWEET TOOTH: *(wailing)* Healthy? Kid, say you don't mean it.

But Stewart meant it, all right. He meant every word. Yes, it was trying. Yes, it was difficult. Okay, it was darn near impossible. But Stewart stayed strong. For The Tooth it was a different story.

SWEET TOOTH: PEAS? YOU'RE GIVING ME PEAS? LITILE DRY GREEN VEGGIE MARBLES? Broccoli? You're feeding me a shrub? THAT'S NOT GOING TO DO IT. DESSERT! WHERE'S

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DESSERT? I'm begging you. WHEN DO WE GET TO THE GOOD STUFF?"

STEWART: *(putting his hands over his ears)* I can't hear you.

Strong. He stayed strong.

SWEET TOOTH: Just one eensy-teensy CHOCOLATE-COVERED PEANUT before hitting the sack. How about it? . . . A nosh. A nibble. A breath mint. Somethin'!

STEWART: *(turning out the light)* Forget it.

Strong. Strong.

SWEET TOOTH: *(at breakfast the next morning as Stewart eats his cereal)* COME ON. WHADDAYA SAY? ONE SPOONFUL OF SUGAR.

Stewart shook his head.

SWEET TOOTH: *(losing his grip)* A DROP OF CHOCOLATE MILK. One measly little crumb-bun crumb.

STEWART: No way.

Very strong.

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SWEET TOOTH: *(shouting)* HEY, WATCH THAT TOOTHBRUSH! AND KEEP THAT TONGUE OF YOURS ON THE OTHER SIDE OF YOUR MOUTH. TRYIN' TO WIGGLE ME OUT OF HERE, HUH? Well, I'm not going, kid. I'm not going anywhere! Do you hear me? . . . Do you hear me?"

Stewart brushed. Flossed. Gargled.

SWEET TOOTH: *(moaning weakly)* U-u-ugh He's not hearing me . . . I'll get you for this, kid.

Stewart smiled. He was winning. Oh yes, he was winning. Three days passed. The Tooth was quiet. Very quiet. Almost too quiet. But Stewart wasn't thinking "tooth." He was thinking baseball. It was the biggest game of the season. Bottom of the ninth. Stewart was at the plate. Runners were on second and third. Two outs. Two strikes. The crowd was on their feet. The game was on the line. Stewart's team was down by one run. The pitcher went into his windup. There was a hush from the stands. A big fat fastball was heading for the plate. It was all up to Stewart. And then . . .

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SWEET TOOTH: BOY, COULD I GO FOR A HUNK OF BUBBLE GUM RIGHT NOW!

Swing! Swish!

SWEET TOOTH: Heh-heh-heh.

UMPIRE: *(yelling)* Strike three! Y'er out!

SWEET TOOTH: Gotcha! Now go get me some goodies!

STEWART: *(mumbling as he drops the bat)* I'll get you goodies.

Home he marched. Into the kitchen. Straight for the refrigerator. He yanked open the door. Rustled through the vegetable bin. He flung lettuce. He tossed tomatoes. He hurled a head of cauliflower. And then he pulled out . . . .a carrot. That's right. A carrot.

STEWART: *(defiantly as he lifts the carrot above his head)* It's over for you, Tooth.

SISTER: *(wide-eyed)* What are you going to do with that?

Stewart grinned. He opened his mouth wide. Very wide.

SWEET TOOTH: KID! NO! NOT THE CARROT! NOT THE CARROT!"

STEWART: *(shouting)* Yes. The carrot!

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SWEET TOOTH: No, kid, no!

SISTER: *(covering her eyes)* Am I too young to be watching this?

Closer. Closer. Closer. And then . . . . CR-CR-CRUNCH.

SWEET TOOTH: Ahhh-ahh-ahhhhh . . . So long, sweet world! . . . What a way to go . . . Done in by an orange veggie.

Stewart rubbed his jaw. He stared at the carrot . . . *(the tooth is in his hand)* and The Tooth. It was over.

SISTER: What's going to happen to it?

Stewart placed the molar under his pillow, then looked at his sister.

STEWART: *(smiling)* Who knows? That's the tooth fairy's problem now.

***** **[In the Tooth Fairy's Bag of Teeth]** ****

BABY TEETH: WAH, WAH, WAH!

CANINE TOOTH: WOOF!

WISDOM TOOTH: Please be quiet. I'm trying to read.

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SWEET TOOTH: Pipe down, wise guy! What does a sweet tooth have to do to get an ice-cream sundae around here? With hot fudge! And throw some sprinkles on it while you're at it.

TOOTH FAIRY: ROTTEN TEETH!

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AWARD HISTORY

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